

Is there such a thing as family porn, a modern weekly rite of passage, where urban Indian families gather together in darkened halls over tubs of popcorn and cans of fizzy drinks, and feel with-it while watching sanctified vulgarity? Does dressing the characters in Robert Cavalli and making them wear Jimmy Choos make it all right to crack cheap jokes about women? Moreover, does it behove major stars to repeatedly indulge in jokes involving passing gas, peeing and being felt up from behind by a large Black woman? No to all. But clearly this is a world where Hollywood is playing second fiddle to Bollywood so anything is possible. A stuntman with the life of a Beverly Hills superstar meets a supermodel masquerading as a surgeon (or is it the other way round?). Neither believes in

love, so sparks fly in a wannabe adaptation of a Hollywood rom-com where a pushy, prissy, posh girl is brought to her senses, and her knees, by a Caveman Throwback. In this case, Akshay Kumar doesn't have to try too hard to be uncouth. The stream of abuse that comes out of his mouth would make even the *Roadies* desperado look gentlemanly. Neither the Valentino bikini nor Sylvester Stallone's fight sequence with the boys in the hood can save this secondhand film with its secondhand plot. I have just two questions. How does Kareena Kapoor's lip gloss stay where it is in spite of Kumar's violent kissing? And was the CBFC asleep when it gave this ugly mess a U/A rating exposing young men to more ways in which they can insult women?

by Kaveree Bamzai

"Rahman Sir is God for me. A genius."

Kailash Kher was initiated into music by his father Mehar S. Kher, a folk singer. He started with Allah ke bande from Waisa Bhi Hota Hai, has released three solo albums so far and sung countless Bollywood songs. He speaks to Associate Editor S. SAHAYA RANJIT on his latest album, *Kailasa Chaandan Mein* (Sony Music).

Q. How is the album different from your others?

A. It has its roots in folk and traditional music. We have mostly used acoustics instruments. Not a single instrument in this album is electronically generated. If we wanted a particular sound, it was brought in from the sands of Rajasthan to even the jungles in Africa.

Q. How much credit do you give to your band members?

A. Full credit. Without them the album would be meaningless.

Q. How was it judging talent hunt shows? Enjoyable?

A. Yes, and flattering when some contestants sang my songs.

Q. And working with A.R. Rahman on Bollywood songs?

A. Rahman Sir is God. A genius. He called me the first time and gave me 16 hours to reach Chennai. When I reached, he asked me to sing whatever I wanted in his studio. And then he promised he would call back. He kept his promise and gave me a break in *Mangal Pandey*.

KAILASH KHER

THEATRE

Hit REPLAY

A SCENE FROM *HAKKI HARUTIDE NODIDIRA*



Written in 1970, *Ashi Paakhare*

Yeti is unlike Vijay Tendulkar's other masterpieces. Subtle and playful without the rawness that was so characteristic of his plays, this play critiques the institution of arranged marriages and the trauma unmarried girls are subjected to in the pre-wedding negotiations. It has been performed in several Indian languages over the years, but remains one of Tendulkar's lesser staged creations. Translated by Prema Karanth and adapted by playwright and director Manav Kaul in Kannada, *Ashi Paakhare Yeti* is a tribute to one of Indian theatre's greatest names. This version in Kannada titled *Hakki Harutide Nodidira* (The Birds are Flying, Do You See?) retains the essence of the playwright's script while infusing it with freshness. Even now, the problems Tendulkar talked about, remain. So go ahead, get a classic take. From July 17 to 23, at Ranga Shankara, Bangalore.

by Nirmala Ravindran